War Games

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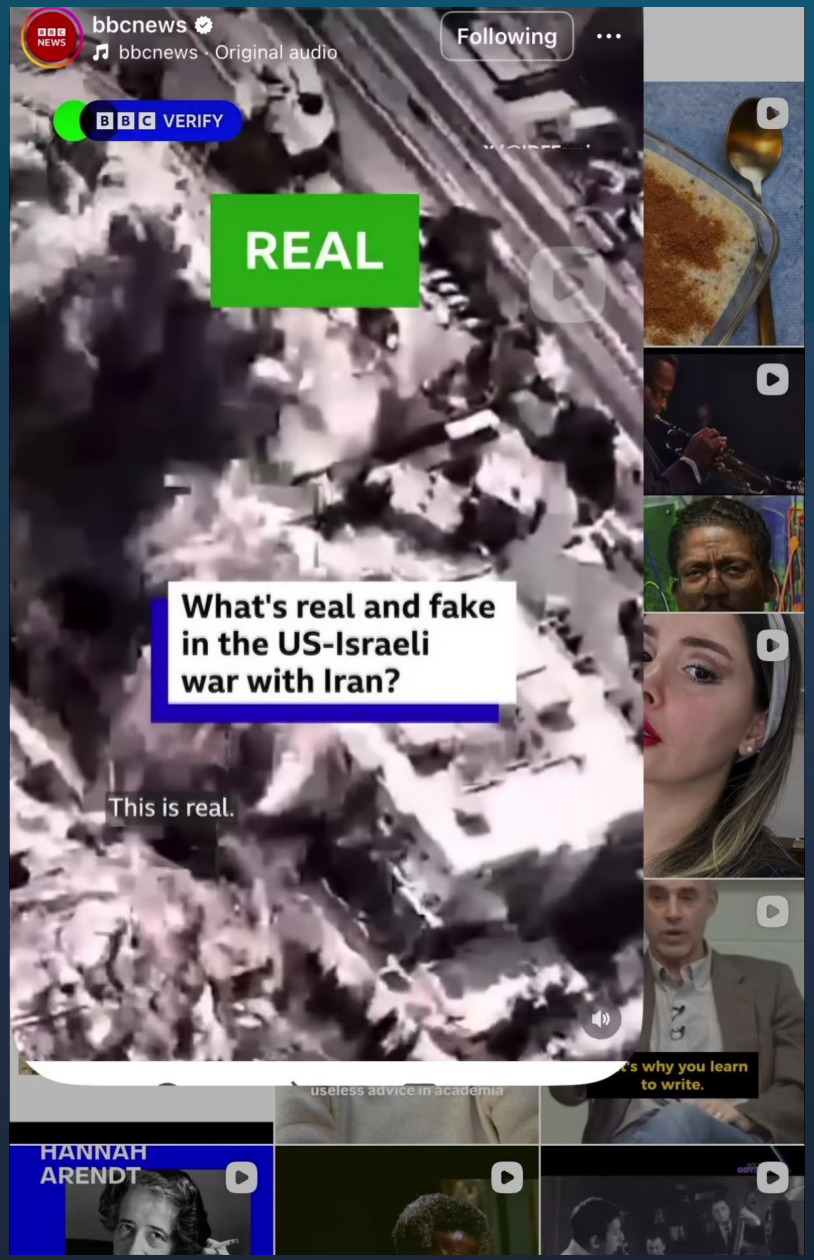
5th March 2026

Theory Discipline

Learning outcomes

- Explain the concept of the **military-entertainment complex**
- Summarise Baudrillard's idea of the **"Nintendo War"**
- Analyse how games may contribute to the **banalisation of war**
- Critically assess whether war games function as propaganda, spectacle, affective thrill, or all three
- Reflect on their own emotional responses to military games

When you think of war, what images come to mind first?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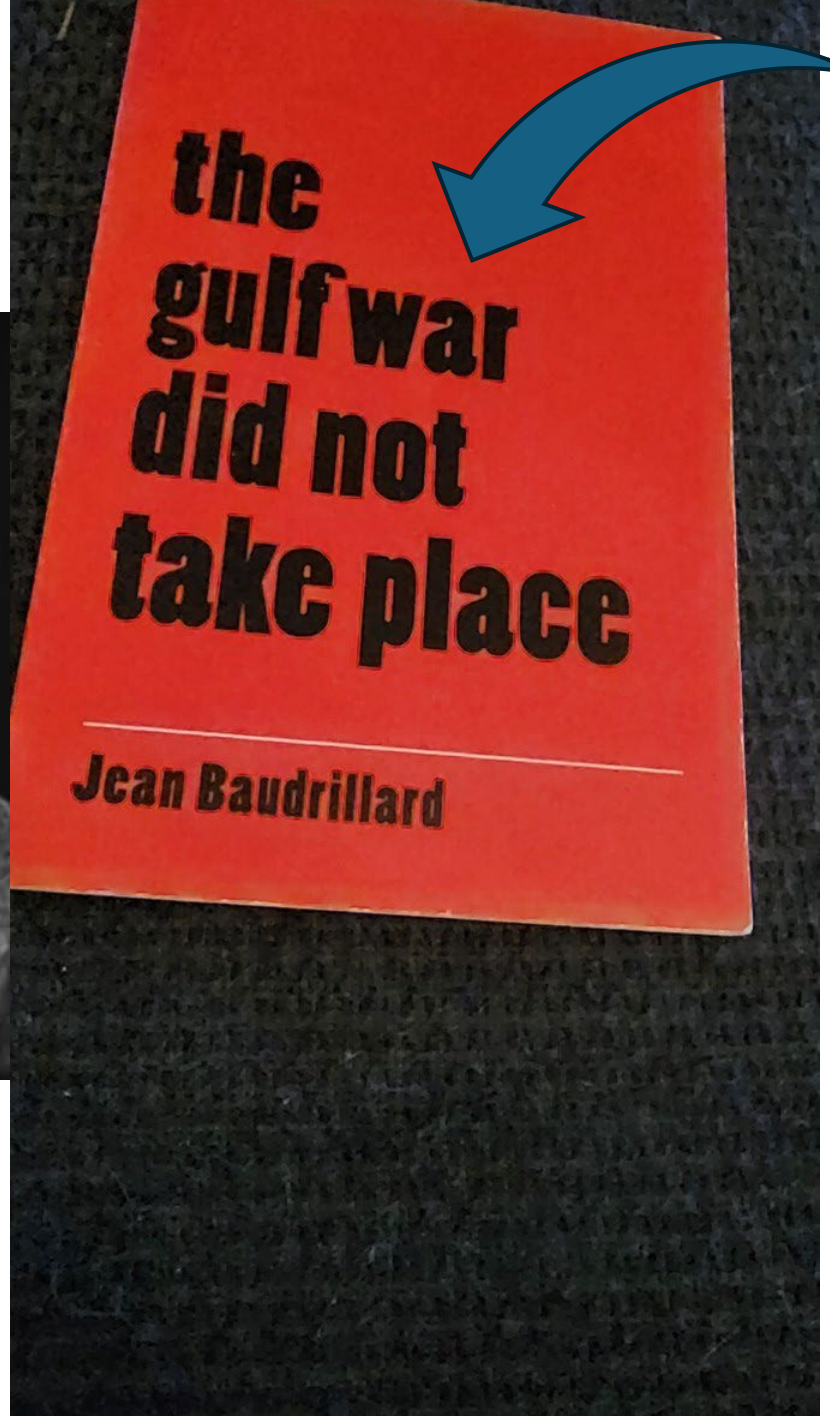
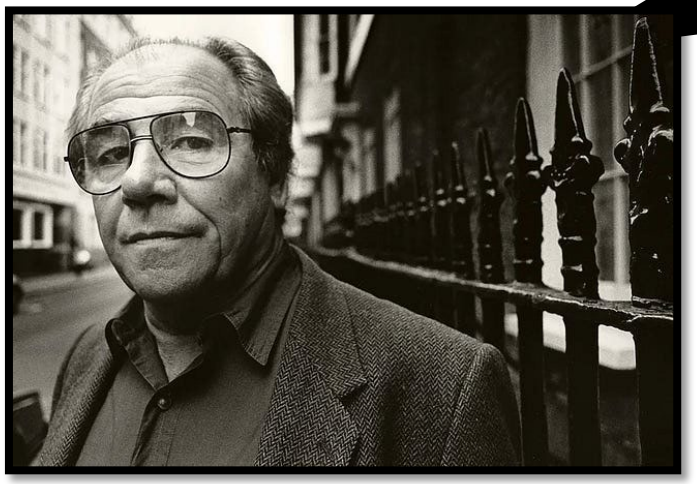


The Gulf War (2 August 1990 – 28 February 1991), was a war waged by coalition forces from 35 nations led by the United States against Iraq in response to Iraq's invasion and annexation of Kuwait

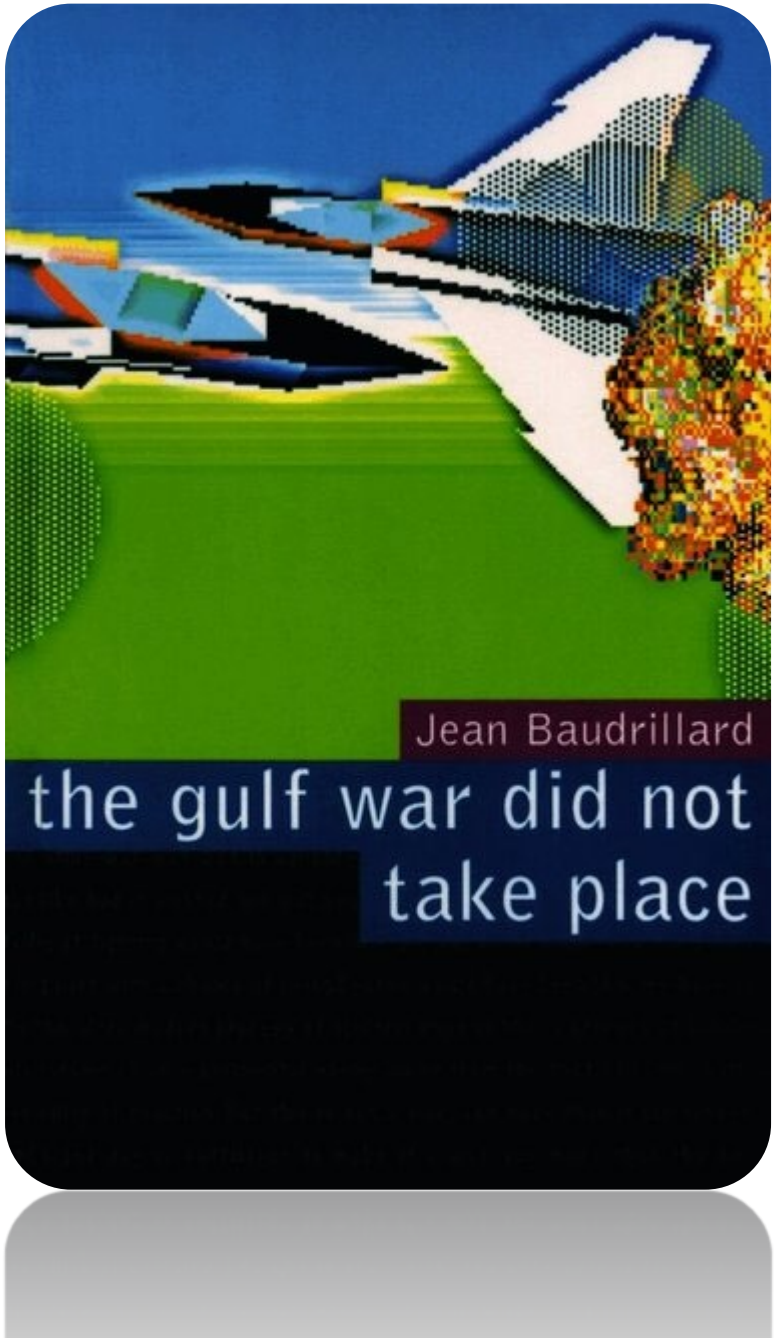
Jean Baudrillard

- ***The Gulf War Did Not Take Place* (1991)**

Not that bombs didn't fall,
but that the war we experienced was mediated.



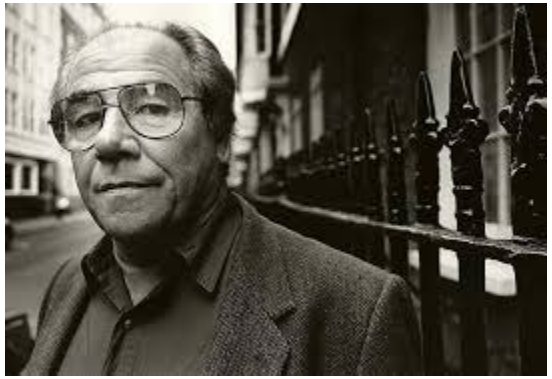
The war was experienced by global audiences as a **media event.**
It existed primarily as **images, simulations, and carefully curated broadcasts**.



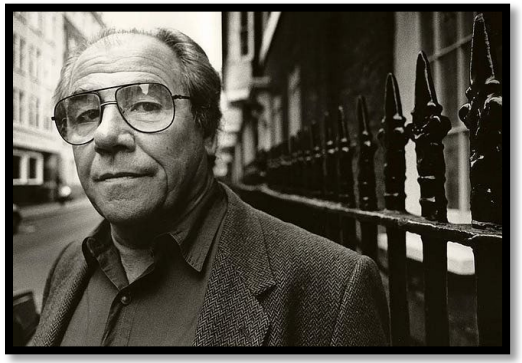
War as media event

- The war is waged in the form of a televisual spectacle.

This is not a war but a ***simulacrum of war, a virtual event*** *which is less the representation of real war than* ***a spectacle*** *which serves a variety of political and strategic purposes on all sides.*
Jean Baudrillard, The Gulf War Did Not Take Place, 1991



Nintendo War



- Unfolds on screens
- Framed by graphics
- Reduced to targets and trajectories
- Something watched at a distance.

If war becomes spectacle,....

First, we become spectators…

- The majority of us encounter war through screens.
  News broadcasts. YouTube clips. Social media. Cinema. And of course, games

Second, violence becomes aestheticised...

- High-resolution explosions.
- Thermal imaging.
- Drone footage that looks almost abstract
- The horror becomes distant.

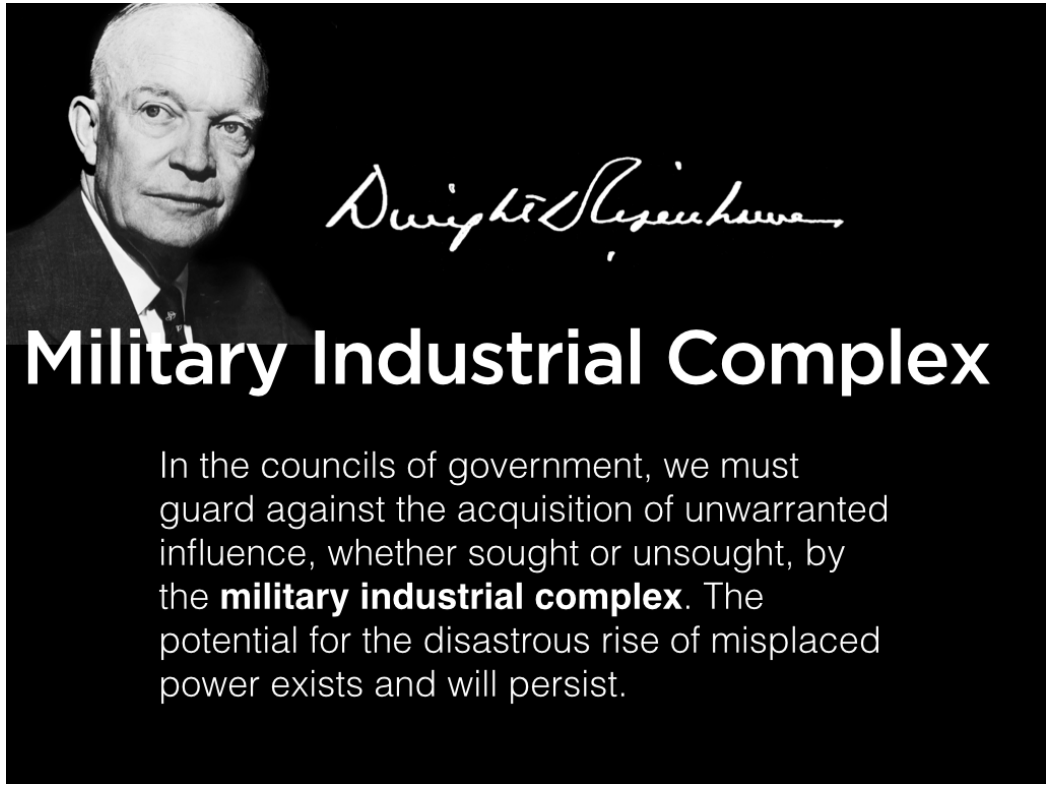
And third, war becomes something we consume…

- We watch it.
  We scroll it.
  We share it.
- This does not mean people stop caring. But it does mean that war enters the same circuits as entertainment.

What happens to its political meaning?

Military Industrial Complex

- The US President Dwight Eisenhower (1961) warned about the:
- **Military–Industrial Complex**
- alliance between:
  - defence contractors
  - government
  - arms industry



Military-Industrial Complex

Military-Entertainment Complex

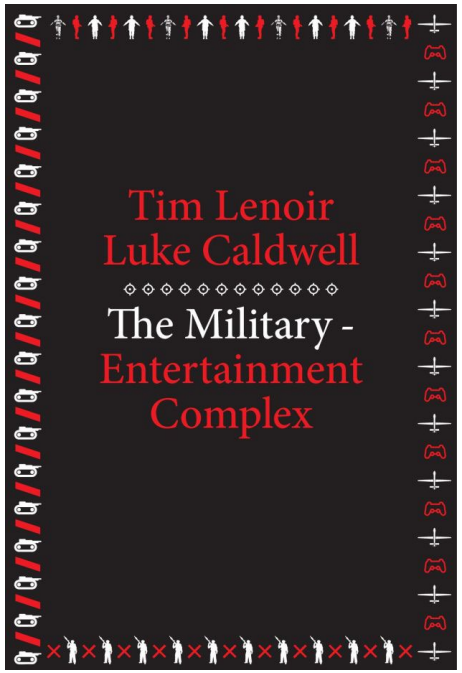
"The military-industrial complex has become the military-entertainment complex."
Timothy Lenoir & Henry Lowood (2002)

War is not only fought on battlefields. It is also simulated, designed, and rehearsed in media industries

Entertainment technologies migrate into military systems.
Military logics migrate into entertainment.

War as simulation

- Simulation technologies developed for entertainment can also be used for:
  - battlefield simulations
  - tactical training
  - remote warfare systems



"The entertainment industry is both a major source of innovative ideas and technology, and a training ground for what might be called post-human warfare."
Lenoir & Lowood (2002)

Shared Technologies

- Military and entertainment industries share:
  - Game engines
  - Simulation software
  - Virtual reality
  - Motion capture
  - Interface design
  - AI modelling

- Examples:
- Flight simulators
- Drone interfaces
- Battlefield simulations

Game engines such as Unreal or Unity can be used for both entertainment and training simulations.

UNREAL ENGINE

Unity

Blurring line between training, simulation, entertainment

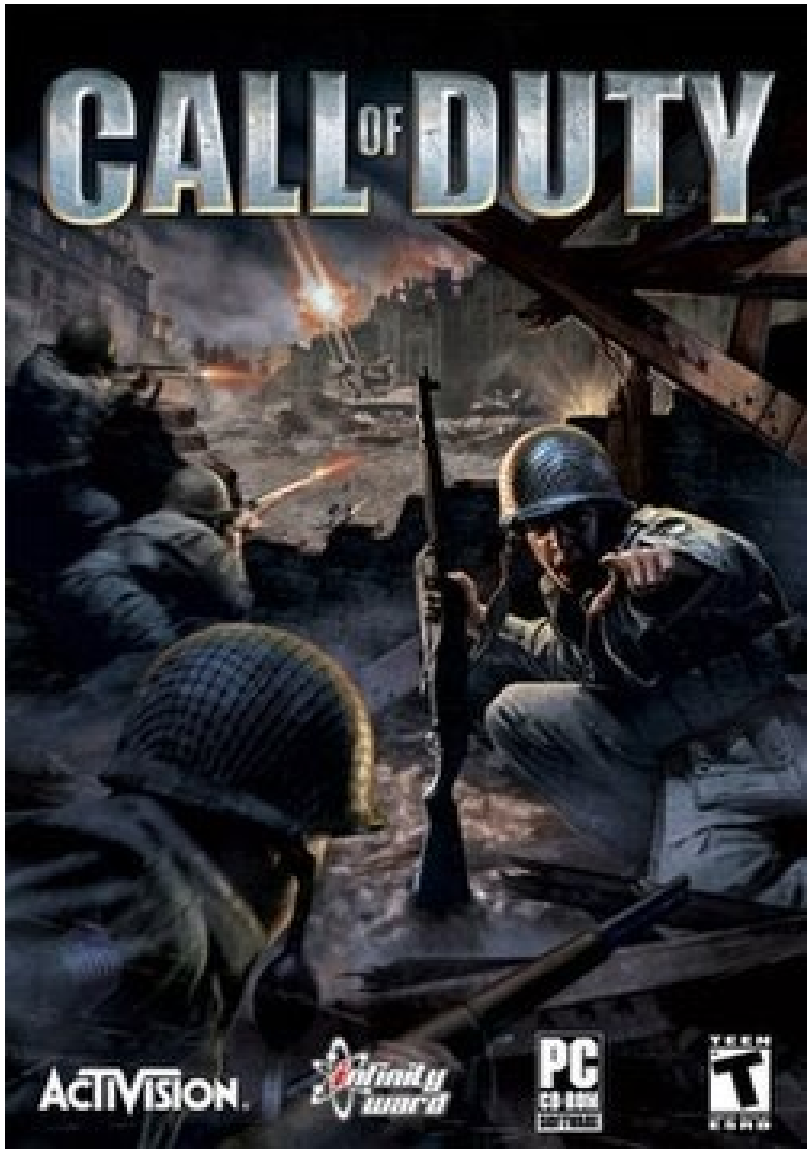
- Developed by the U.S. Army
- Recruitment and training tool

Developed from military simulation training

These games are not purely entertainment, they serve institutional purposes.

High intensity spectacle...

- cinematic camera angles
- dramatic explosions
- scripted action sequences
- heroic music
- Slow motion combat moments



The player takes the role of **elite soldiers**...

- heroism
- competence
- technological superiority
- military professionalism

simplifies political conflicts into...

- clear enemies
- clear missions
- clear victory conditions

The Military–Entertainment Complex

- uses military advisors
- recreates weapons and equipment
- presents modern military technology in detailed ways

- This creates a form of **military spectacle combined with entertainment media**.

- **normalisation of military power and technology**